

Chapter 153-1

This evening banquet had gathered the elite of Haizhou City.

Using charity as a pretext to make connections.

Everyone who came knew that Old Master Qin was advanced in years, and the Qin family's branch lineages were tangled and complex. On the surface, Qin Liushuang was in charge, but there were still many juniors in the Qin Corporation eyeing the position covetously.

And there was also Qin Lishuang, who acted recklessly relying on Old Master Qin's favor.

No one knew whose hands the Qin family would ultimately fall into.

So everyone present was watching and waiting.

Zhao Xuning was also among those invited.

She originally had no intention of coming, but after hearing from her sister that people from both the Shen and Gu families would be attending, she rushed over after finishing a surgery, going home to shower and change into formal attire.

As the second young miss of the Zhao family who rarely made public appearances, Zhao Xuning didn't need to be busy socializing like her sister, holding a wine glass and maneuvering through the crowd.

After arriving, she found a quiet corner to sit in, undisturbed.

She did see Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu though.

At such an evening banquet, Xu Qingzhu naturally had things to do, unlike idle people like her.

So she only sent a message to Liang Shi: 【Northwest.】

Brief and to the point.

When Liang Shi saw the message, she quickly understood her meaning, and their gazes met across the room.

But Liang Shi replied: 【Busy tonight.】

Zhao Xuning: 【.....】

Unable to find a companion to hang out with, Zhao Xuning stayed quietly by herself.

Beneath the surface of this seemingly calm evening banquet, undercurrents were surging.

Before long, Zhao Xuning went outside to get some fresh air.

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Zhao Xuning didn't expect to run into Shen Hui's older sister outside.

The other woman was standing in a corner against the wall, making a phone call, her voice cold and low.

Between leaving and staying, she decisively chose to leave.

But before she could take two steps, she met the other woman's gaze head-on.

The other woman wore a watch with a very thin band, likely a high-end custom piece, looking quite valuable.

A simple white shirt and black trousers were worn by her with an air of expensive luxury. Even in the slightly cold outdoors, her shirt sleeves were still rolled up a bit.

She looked shrewd and capable.

Suddenly feeling the awkwardness of being caught, Zhao Xuning nodded slightly at her.

But Shen Fenghe suddenly spoke: "Zhao Xuning?"

Having been called by name, she naturally couldn't pretend not to see her anymore.

Zhao Xuning's footsteps halted. "Mm."

Shen Fenghe had already walked closer to her and said calmly and directly: "Shen Hui didn't come tonight."

Having her thoughts exposed, Zhao Xuning stiffened and immediately said: "I wasn't..."

Before she could finish, Shen Fenghe interrupted her with a firm tone: "She doesn't participate in any company matters."

This kind of banquet was company business.

Zhao Xuning didn't know what Shen Fenghe's intentions were in saying these things.

The narrowness and sense of oppression from back when they were abroad returned. She was about the same height as Shen Fenghe, and looked straight at her, feigning composure: "Miss Shen, what do you mean by that?"

"What I mean is..." Shen Fenghe paused, and her gaze toward Zhao Xuning suddenly became sharp and piercing, "Give up."

Cold without a trace of warmth.

As if she knew they had been in love for many years, and so even after breaking up, it was hard to let go.

Shen Fenghe spoke in an extremely calm tone, her eyes conveying only one message—there's no need to make excuses to me, I know everything.

There were no questions or interrogations. Just like when she went abroad to bring Shen Hui back, she didn't curse at her, nor did she hurl any insults or abuse, nor did she make any personal attacks. She simply said three words calmly to Zhao Xuning: "Break it off."

After that, there was no room for negotiation.

This time was exactly the same as back then.

After a moment, Zhao Xuning asked her: "Did Shen Hui ask you to say this to me?"

"She doesn't know." Shen Fenghe was also very honest, composed and calm, as if she were handling business matters, seemingly at ease with everything. "I just happened to run into you, so I'm kindly giving you a reminder."

Zhao Xuning paused. "President Shen and I don't seem to have the kind of relationship where we can get along so amicably."

"Mm." Shen Fenghe was blunt. "You can see it as my rare kindness, or you can see it as... me leaving you some dignity."

Zhao Xuning: "..."

The edge that had been restrained for so long now showed itself slightly. "What if I insist?"

Shen Fenghe's gaze swept lightly over her features, and she said calmly: "You can try."

"My father still doesn't know about you and Ah Hui." Shen Fenghe said, "My father has always been partial to Ah Hui. If he knew Ah Hui had suffered such grievances, there's no telling what he might do, and the Zhao family would suffer along with you."

"As far as I know, Mr. and Mrs. Zhao looked down on our Ah Hui back then." Shen Fenghe spoke unhurriedly, as if making casual conversation, but the aura she casually exuded made it clear she wasn't just making small talk. "If I have the chance to meet Mr. Zhao next time, I should ask him—in what way exactly is our Ah Hui not good enough for Miss Zhao?"

Seemingly calm, yet every word struck at the heart.

Zhao Xuning closed her eyes briefly. "President Shen, is this a threat?"

"It's not 'is this.'" Shen Fenghe said, "It is."

Zhao Xuning: "..."

"So what did you hear from Shen Hui?" Zhao Xuning asked in return lightly.

Shen Fenghe paused. "She's never mentioned anything since returning to the country."

"Then why do you think I'm a threat?" Zhao Xuning continued to press.

"Shen Hui is going on blind dates." Shen Fenghe didn't hide it. "If you appear in front of her frequently, it will make her unhappy."

Shen Fenghe lowered her head to glance at her watch, her speech quickening. "I don't want to see Ah Hui unhappy."

After saying this, she nodded with distant but polite courtesy: "I have other matters to attend to. I'll take my leave first."

Leaving Zhao Xuning standing there alone in a daze.

So, she was now an existence that would make Shen Hui unhappy.

Chapter 153-2

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Liang Shi planned to follow Xu Qingzhu closely tonight. Knowing that Xu Qingzhu would fall into the water tonight, she certainly wouldn't leave her side.

Walking together with Xu Qingzhu, they attracted quite a few amazed gazes.

Even though the banquet hall was like a garden with flowers competing for beauty, she and Xu Qingzhu still managed to stand out in this setting.

Xu Qingzhu showed no timidity in such occasions. Between exchanging toasts, she had already greeted those who had once been on good terms with the Sheng family.

Before long, they saw Su Zhe and his wife, the two of them arm in arm.

Liang Shi nodded in greeting to the pair: "Uncle, Auntie."

Su Zhe swept a light glance over her and Xu Qingzhu, and reminded them: "Mm, it's just a small evening banquet. No need to be so formal."

Xu Qingzhu had already greeted everyone she needed to greet. After that, there wasn't much else to do except see who would take the initiative to come and make their acquaintance.

The high heels Xu Qingzhu wore tonight were quite tall, making it somewhat tiring to stand.

So the two of them simply found a place to sit.

After eight o'clock, the door leading to the swimming pool opened, and the banquet hall's space expanded.

In an instant, all the lights in the banquet hall lit up. The dazzling light strips on both sides of the swimming pool reflected off each other, and the open-air starry ceiling was understated yet luxurious.

The banquet officially reached its climax.

People around them came and went, bustling about, all wearing amiable smiles on their faces.

Socialites gathered in small groups of three to five, chatting away, discussing who knows which family's gossip.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu also saw Liang Xinzhou and Yu Wan. Yu Wan was already visibly pregnant, and the dress she wore was a size larger than usual.

Obviously, the two of them had also come representing different factions.

Liang Xinzhou represented the Liang family, while Yu Wan represented the Yu family.

Liang Xinzhou had already returned to work at Dongheng. Although Liang Xinran wasn't brought back to the old residence due to their group's insistence, Father Liang and Qiu Zimin had bought her an apartment in the city center for her to live alone.

Occasionally, Qiu Zimin would also go there to stay overnight.

This "occasionally" was quite a conservative estimate—it was almost three to four days a week that she would stay with Liang Xinran.

The mother and daughter would either go shopping together, do spa treatments together, or attend gatherings with Qiu Zimin's friends, always bringing Liang Xinran along.

Liang Shi had learned all this from her two sisters-in-law.

Although Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe had moved out of the old residence, they would still go back for a family reunion dinner once a week.

Before Liang Xinzhou had returned to the company, Liang Xinran hadn't appeared at their family dining table.

But as soon as Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe returned to their positions, Liang Xinran went back.

Qiu Zimin had plenty of excuses.

It was just one meal, so Liang Xinzhou didn't make a fuss about it.

Fortunately, after the previous commotion, Qiu Zimin and Liang Xinran had settled down considerably. After the two Liang brothers moved out of the old residence, the family was harmonious. With distance from Qiu Zimin, their relationship had actually returned to how it was before.

But with Liang Xinran standing between them, things would never return to how they originally were.

After greeting Liang Xinzhou and Yu Wan, Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu finally had some leisure time.

The banquet hall was crowded with people, noisy and clamorous.

Liang Shi kept watching the people around them, looking everywhere but she didn't see Qin Lishuang.

Let alone Lu Jiayi.

She did see Sun Chengcheng though, flitting about in the crowd like a colorful butterfly.

Liang Shi inadvertently met her gaze, then gave her a disdainful glance before looking away.

However, Sun Chengcheng was extremely surprised. She had been chatting with a lady she was very interested in, but her expression suddenly changed dramatically, making the lady think she had fallen ill.

Little did she know that Sun Chengcheng was simply feeling surprised.

Standing beside Liang Shi was none other than Xu Qingzhu.

These two actually knew each other?

And their relationship didn't look shallow either.

So... Sun Chengcheng wasn't stupid. In an instant, she connected all the previous events with the present.

So... Liang Shi, like her, had chosen this world?

Everything before had all been an act?

But how could she have faked it so convincingly?

After coming to this realization, Sun Chengcheng's face instantly turned deathly pale, without a trace of color.

With Liang Shi here, could she... could she still successfully capture Xu Qingzhu's heart?

No wonder Xu Qingzhu had always been lukewarm toward her.

Sun Chengcheng's surprise had already turned into secret hatred.

Liang Shi naturally noticed, but paid her no attention. All her thoughts were now on Xu Qingzhu.

This nervousness was also detected by Xu Qingzhu.

Chapter 153-3

Xu Qingzhu asked her: "What are you nervous about?"

"Nothing." Liang Shi answered in a low voice, looking somewhat guilty.

"Did you see Sun Chengcheng?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi nodded.

Seeing that she still had a guarded expression, Xu Qingzhu couldn't help but hook her fingers to tease her. "Come on, our relationship can't be hidden anymore."

Liang Shi chuckled softly: "I never intended to hide it anyway."

"But how did she get invited? Her family shouldn't meet the invitation standards." Xu Qingzhu was puzzled, and took the opportunity to tell her about what had happened with Sun Chengcheng before. "She's very strange. She always appears in front of me in various ways. We're clearly not that close, yet I feel like I've known her for a long time. But I still don't like her."

"Why?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her, picked up the wine glass in front of her and took a light sip, as if to say—how could you not know why?

"She bullied you before." Xu Qingzhu said, "Very annoying."

"You even remember that?"

"Of course."

The two chatted intermittently. Obviously, neither of them was really in the mood for conversation.

Their minds had long wandered elsewhere.

After a while, Liang Shi still couldn't help herself and reminded Xu Qingzhu in a low voice: "Don't go near the water tonight, okay?"

"What do you mean?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Xu Qingzhu was too clever. It was just a simple reminder, but after thinking about it, she asked in return: "So my dream will happen tonight?"

"No." Liang Shi said, "Those dreams of yours are all fake. I won't kill you."

Saying such things amidst the elegant duet of cello and piano was really quite a mood killer.

But the two parties involved didn't notice.

Xu Qingzhu paused slightly: "But my dream takes place underwater."

"I've felt like I was drowning in water countless times, as if someone pushed me in." Xu Qingzhu said, "I can swim, but in that moment, I couldn't exert any strength in the water.."

Liang Shi pursed her lips: "And then?"

"You pointed a knife at me." Xu Qingzhu said, "In the water... you pointed a knife at me, and then as I continued to sink, someone came to save me."

"That person made me feel very safe." Xu Qingzhu didn't hide anything, but hearing this made Liang Shi's heart feel blocked.

It must be Lu Jiayi.

But until now, Lu Jiayi still hadn't appeared.

Where was she hiding?

Or perhaps Lu Jiayi wouldn't appear in public tonight, and would only show up when saving Xu Qingzhu.

After all, she was a new elite from the capital. If Lu Jiayi appeared, there would certainly be many people wanting to curry favor with her.

But Liang Shi still didn't understand why Lu Jiayi and Qin Lishuang would be together.

What exactly was the relationship between these two?

There seemed to be quite an age gap between them too.

The original plot stated that Lu Jiayi was 26 years old, which could certainly be described as accomplished at a young age.

Liang Shi didn't know any of this either.

She only heard Xu Qingzhu continue: "But I couldn't see her face clearly."

Liang Shi thought to herself, I haven't seen her face either.

That day, she had been covered up too thoroughly.

Whenever Xu Qingzhu brought up that dream, a deep sense of exhaustion would surround her—a helplessness that even others could feel.

Liang Shi reached out and squeezed her fingers, signaling her to feel at ease.

But in truth, her own heart was also in turmoil.

Because she didn't know at which point things would happen, she could only keep taking precautions.

Once Old Master Qin made his appearance at this banquet, everyone would be able to leave.

Liang Shi was waiting for that moment. She had to take Xu Qingzhu away early.

Chapter 153-4

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20:27.

Sun Chengcheng glanced at the time. Only ten minutes left.

But Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu were still over there chatting as if no one else existed.

The only place at this banquet that met the conditions was the swimming pool outside the other door.

There were quite a few people standing over there now, all admiring the beautiful open-air starry ceiling.

Sun Chengcheng was secretly anxious inside. She had prepared for so long...

And she hadn't seen Lu Jiayi either. In this banquet hall, no one matching Lu Jiayi's description had appeared.

20:30.

Xu Qingzhu and Liang Shi were still sitting there, sometimes chatting and laughing, sometimes making little intimate gestures.

Sun Chengcheng had already gotten up and gone near the swimming pool.

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Qin Lishuang had smoked three cigarettes in the lounge. It was very choking.

Lu Jiayi frowned. "Stop smoking."

"I'm thinking." Qin Lishuang said, "Miss Lu, I wonder if you'd be willing to help?"

"No." Lu Jiayi refused. "I won't get involved in your affairs."

Qin Lishuang curved her lips into a light smile. "How boring."

Lu Jiayi neither agreed nor disagreed with her assessment.

"I'll go myself then." Qin Lishuang said, "Just don't try to stop me."

Lu Jiayi's hand, which had been lowered playing with her phone, paused. "Not necessarily."

Qin Lishuang was startled: "I trust Miss Lu won't be so meddlesome."

A game sound came from Lu Jiayi's phone—she had just cleared a level of Match-3¹. She turned off the phone screen, put the phone in her suit pocket, stood up and walked toward the door. "I'm leaving first."

"Don't." Qin Lishuang lightly applied a layer of lipstick to her lips, making her look even more alluring. "You stay here. I'll go."

After saying that, Qin Lishuang rummaged through her bag and pulled out a small packet of something, weighing it in her hand while revealing an evil smile.

"What's that?" Lu Jiayi asked casually.

Qin Lishuang curved her lips: "Just a little something that can make people lose their strength."

Lu Jiayi: "..."

Just as Qin Lishuang was about to leave, she heard Lu Jiayi say: "How despicable."

Qin Lishuang's footsteps paused. She didn't refute it, and left happily.

Only Lu Jiayi was left alone in the lounge. She opened the window and looked down. It was no different from the capital—all people holding wine glasses and socializing.

She had come here at the request of her younger aunt, to deliver something to Old Master Qin.

And to lay low for a while.

She had just had a fight with her eldest younger brother at home and had almost come to blows.

It was an impulsive moment, and she had given him ammunition to use against her, putting her in a passive position with her father.

So her younger aunt gave her an idea—retreat in order to advance.

She had come to Haizhou City overnight.

According to her younger aunt, the influential powers in Haizhou City were also tangled and complex. Taking this opportunity, she could get to know more people.

Her younger aunt had told her at the time to get close to Qin Lishuang and not to offend Qin Lishuang.

After arriving, she hadn't met Qin Lishuang many times, and had only gotten to know Qin Lishuang.

Probably because Qin Lishuang had too much free time.

But no matter what, she was still a direct descendant of the Lu family, the legally designated first heir.

If the Qin family and the Lu family were to marry, no matter how you looked at it, it was the Qin family reaching above their station.

Lu Jiayi didn't need to watch anyone's expression while she was here.

She really did look down on Qin Lishuang's conduct—too despicable. Although she wasn't an artist herself, she knew that even art had to have a baseline of human decency.

But a strong dragon cannot suppress a local snake². No matter what bastard things Qin Lishuang did, Old Master Qin would cover for her.

What did it have to do with her?

Lu Jiayi stood by the window enjoying the breeze for a while. Looking down, she happened to see two figures in blue.

Both of them were quite attractive, standing out in the crowd.

She couldn't see clearly with the naked eye, so Lu Jiayi took out her phone and snapped a photo.

After zooming in, she discovered it was actually the person she had met at the entrance of the art museum that day, along with the one in the photo Qin Lishuang had shown her earlier.

The person in real life was probably even more beautiful than in the photo.

Lu Jiayi closed the window and continued playing Match-3.

But after playing two rounds, she suddenly stood up.

That person she had met at the entrance of the art museum that day... had quite beautiful eyes.

Very similar to the eyes of her friend's fiancée.

If she remembered correctly, that fiancée should also be one of the top elites in Haizhou City.

It couldn't hurt to make an acquaintance.

Thinking this, Lu Jiayi got up and headed out.

Footnotes:

¹ Match-3: Refers to "消消乐" (xiāo xiāo lè), a popular puzzle game genre in China similar to Candy Crush where players match three or more identical items to clear them from the board.

² A strong dragon cannot suppress a local snake (强龙不压地头蛇): A Chinese proverb meaning that even a powerful outsider cannot easily overcome local powers who have established influence in their territory.

Chapter 153-5

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Xu Qingzhu received a phone call from Sheng Linlang, and since it was too noisy inside, Liang Shi accompanied her outside to take the call.

Sheng Linlang was also someone who rarely called her. This time she was calling to ask if she had returned, saying it had been a long time since they'd seen each other. She wanted to invite Su Yao and the others to come to her house tomorrow so they could all get together.

Xu Qingzhu agreed.

Afterward, the two exchanged pleasantries for a while before hanging up.

The wind was strong outside, and Xu Qingzhu's nose had turned red from the cold.

Liang Shi was no better off.

After hanging up, Liang Shi asked her what time it was.

Xu Qingzhu glanced at her phone: "Half past eight."

It was actually 20:32.

Liang Shi complained: "Who knows when Old Master Qin will show up."

Xu Qingzhu moved closer to her, the two standing close together to ward off the cold wind. "Actually, we could leave now."

"Never mind." Liang Shi pulled her back inside. "I shouldn't hold Teacher Xu back."

Xu Qingzhu was amused by her. "What's that supposed to mean?"

"Small things accumulate into big things." Liang Shi said as they walked back together. "We should always let President Xu maintain a good reputation."

"So now I'm President Xu again." Xu Qingzhu glanced at her. "How many more nicknames can you come up with for me?"

"I don't know." Liang Shi said, "That depends on how many professions you have."

Xu Qingzhu clicked her tongue and was about to say something when she saw Liang Shi's expression change slightly. She turned her head and saw Qin Lishuang.

Qin Lishuang was standing at the spot where they had been sitting earlier, swirling a glass of wine in her hand, looking quite charming.

On Qin Lishuang's turf, Liang Shi didn't want to confront her head-on, so she pulled Xu Qingzhu intending to leave. But Qin Lishuang said: "Little Ah Shi, since we've already met, won't you bring your wife over for a drink?"

Qin Lishuang was quite brazen.

Liang Shi frowned: "No need."

"Just one glass." Qin Lishuang smiled lightly. "What's wrong with the younger generation these days? Don't they know how to respect their elders?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Qin Lishuang kept talking, clearly implying she wouldn't let them leave unless they drank. Hearing this, Xu Qingzhu's brows furrowed slightly. She stepped forward and looked at Qin Lishuang: "Miss Qin, my Ah Shi can't hold her liquor well. I'll drink this glass for her."

Xu Qingzhu looked at her, but instead of taking her own wine from the table, she asked a passing server for a glass, then walked up to clink glasses with Qin Lishuang.

Qin Lishuang's expression changed slightly, but she said nothing.

One glass of wine was drained.

Xu Qingzhu set the wine glass on the table. "Miss Qin, we have other matters to attend to. We'll take our leave first."

Qin Lishuang made a sound of acknowledgment and mentioned: "The starry ceiling over there is quite nice. Suitable for you lovebirds to look at."

With that, she left.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu didn't want to see her again, so they went over.

Liang Shi absolutely didn't dare let Xu Qingzhu get close to the pool area. Xu Qingzhu just laughed at her: "I can swim, you know."

Liang Shi shook her head: "That still won't do."

She was trying to change this major event.

They had only been standing there for less than two minutes when Sun Chengcheng walked over. "What a coincidence, Qingzhu. Didn't expect to run into you here."

Xu Qingzhu nodded. "Mm."

Liang Shi stood to the side and said quite haughtily: "You didn't see me? Don't you think that's a coincidence?"

"It is quite a coincidence." Sun Chengcheng said awkwardly.

But just as those words fell, another voice came: "It really is quite a coincidence."

Turning around, they found it was Gu Yixue.

The three people from the production crew had gathered here, momentarily at a loss for what to say.

Liang Shi greeted Gu Yixue, while Xu Qingzhu's phone rang and she went aside to answer it.

20:41.

The time when Xu Qingzhu was supposed to fall into the water had already passed. Sun Chengcheng was secretly anxious inside.

Could it be that this event didn't have to happen?

Then wouldn't she miss her chance to see Lu Jiayi?

But then, just as Xu Qingzhu had walked only a few steps away, someone by the poolside cried out: "Ouch..."

A little girl had fallen down.

Xu Qingzhu rushed over when she saw it, but before she could help the little girl up, her own body went limp and she fell backward.

Splash.

"Big sister!" The little girl who had fallen tried to grab her, but couldn't hold on.

Even while talking to Gu Yixue, Liang Shi had been constantly watching Xu Qingzhu's movements. When she saw her fall into the water, she immediately ran over.

But in that instant, her body felt as heavy as a thousand pounds, unable to run.

By the time she jumped into the water, another splash had already sounded.

To her, it felt like slow-motion replay, but in reality, everything happened in the blink of an eye.

Liang Shi was also very fast, but the moment Xu Qingzhu fell into the water, a figure in white followed immediately after, jumping directly into the water to save Xu Qingzhu.

Liang Shi entered the water right behind.

...

This sequence of events was like dumplings being dropped into a pot one after another¹.

Liang Shi was an excellent swimmer, but when she saw Xu Qingzhu underwater, her blue gauze dress had spread out in the water like a blooming flower.

And that flower was being held in the arms of that white figure.

In the instant Liang Shi swam over, she saw the slightly terrified look in Xu Qingzhu's eyes.

Her movements suddenly stopped, and in that moment, she had the thought of just letting things take their course.

But not even two seconds later, another figure appeared underwater.

She didn't know if it was her imagination, but Liang Shi thought she saw Zhao Xuning.

Footnotes:

¹ Like dumplings being dropped into a pot (跟下饺子似的): A Chinese expression used to describe multiple people or things entering water in quick succession, likening it to the way dumplings are dropped one after another into boiling water when cooking.